



NCYSA UPDATE:

NCYSA Classic League Matches - IFAB Law 3 – Time-Limited Substitution Protocol

This newly revamped Law 3 introduces an updated substitution protocol ***designed to prevent time-wasting and disruption of the tempo of the match.***

FOR NCYSA CLASSIC LEAGUE MATCHES

AMENDED IMPLEMENTATION of Law 3: PROTOCOL:

August 21, 2026 – For immediate effect on NCYSA Classic League Matches

In an effort to preserve the intent of the updated Law 3 while adapting its application to be appropriate for varying levels of play and practical league circumstances, **NCYSA has established the following modified protocol, effective immediately.**

- If a player is exiting the field as expected and not delaying their exit the referee does not need to initiate a 10-Second Count.
- If a player is **unnecessarily delaying a substitution** by failing to leave the field in a timely manner, the referee will whistle to initiate a **10-second countdown**. The referee will visually count down the 10 seconds using one raised hand, and the exiting player **must be off the field before the countdown expires**.
- Except when leaving the field within the allotted 10 seconds **is not possible due to injury, safety, or security concerns**, a player who fails to exit the field before the 10-second countdown expires will be subject to the following:
 - The **incoming substitute may not enter the field immediately**. The incoming substitute must remain off the field and may enter only with the referee's permission at the **first stoppage after one minute has elapsed following the restart of play**.
- If the **outgoing player has not left the field of play within the required 10 seconds** after the referee initiates the count, the following will apply:
 - The **incoming substitute must remain off the field** and may only enter with the referee's permission at the first stoppage after one minute has elapsed following the restart of play.

RATIONALE FOR AMENDED IMPLEMENTATION:

In NCYSA Classic matches, **player safety remains the priority, and substituted players must exit the field at midfield or near their team bench**. A delay caused by this type of exit is not a violation of the count.

Because of this requirement and the standard substitution procedures used in Classic matches, a substitution may reasonably take longer than 10 seconds without being considered an unnecessary delay.

Under this adapted protocol, referees will have the discretion to determine when a player is **unnecessarily delaying a substitution** and, at that point, initiate the 10-second countdown.

This approach prioritizes player safety while introducing players to the intent of the updated Law and giving referees the discretion to appropriately address deliberate or unnecessary delays.